PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 02



DELHI & PUNJAB ORIGIN

Dal Makhani

Slow-Simmered Black Lentils
Punjab's Richest Comfort Food

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Dal Makhani

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Dal Makhani

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Built on Patience

Dal makhani shares its origin story with butter chicken and butter paneer, emerging from the same wave of Punjabi and Peshawari refugee kitchens that rebuilt Delhi's food scene after Partition — Moti Mahal is again widely credited as the restaurant where this specific version of the dish was refined and popularized in the 1950s.

What makes dal makhani distinct is its method more than any single ingredient: whole black lentils (urad dal) and red kidney beans, simmered for hours — traditionally overnight over the dying embers of a tandoor — until they break down into a thick, velvety, almost creamy consistency entirely from the long cooking itself, before butter and cream are folded in at the end. This slow transformation is what separates a truly great dal makhani from an ordinary one.

The name comes directly from "makhan," Hindi for butter, and the dish delivers on that promise — it's arguably the richest, most indulgent lentil dish in Indian cuisine, equally at home on a five-star hotel menu and a family's Sunday dinner table.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Built on Patience, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Born from the same Delhi refugee-restaurant tradition as butter chicken and butter paneer, refined at Moti Mahal in the 1950s. Traditionally simmered for many hours, historically overnight over dying tandoor embers, a technique still followed by dedicated home cooks and restaurants today. A celebratory dish often served at weddings, festivals, and special family gatherings rather than a strictly everyday meal, owing to its richness and long cooking time.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	4–8h	6	Med
ACTIVE PREP	SIMMER TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (strongly recommended to shorten the long cooking time)
- Heavy-bottomed pot, for the slow-simmer finish
- Kadai or wide pan for the gravy
- Wooden spoon for regular stirring

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Dal makhani keeps refrigerated for up to 5 days and, like most slow-cooked dishes, tastes noticeably better the next day as the flavors continue to meld. It freezes exceptionally well for up to 3 months — a great make-ahead dish for batch cooking. Reheat gently over low heat with a splash of water or milk to loosen the consistency.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the lentils

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Whole black lentils (urad dal, sabut)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Red kidney beans (rajma), dried	¼ cup	50 g	¼ katori
Water, for cooking	4 cups	1 L	4 katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the gravy

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Butter	4 tbsp	60 g	4 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 large	150 g	1 large
Ginger-garlic paste	1½ tbsp	22 g	1½ chammach
Tomato puree	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Kashmiri red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Heavy cream	¼ cup	60 ml	¼ katori
Kasuri methi, crushed	1 tsp	1 g	1 chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Whole black lentils (sabut urad, sometimes labeled "whole black gram") are the essential base and don't have a good substitute — they're widely available at Indian grocers and online. Canned red kidney beans and canned black beans can shortcut the cooking time considerably if you're short on time, though the texture won't be quite as rich as beans cooked from dried. Cream can be reduced or replaced with extra butter for a slightly lighter, though still indulgent, version.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Lentils and Beans

01 SOAK OVERNIGHT

Rinse the black lentils and kidney beans together and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours. This significantly shortens the cooking time and improves texture.

02 PRESSURE COOK UNTIL VERY SOFT

Drain and pressure cook the soaked lentils and beans with 4 cups fresh water and salt for 8–10 whistles, until completely soft and starting to break down — much softer than you'd cook lentils for most other dishes.

03 SIMMER AND MASH SLIGHTLY

Transfer to a heavy-bottomed pot and simmer gently for at least 1 hour, mashing some of the lentils against the side of the pot with your spoon as you stir — this is what builds the dish's characteristic creamy texture from within.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Lentils and Beans, continued



Chef tip. the longer this simmers, the better — traditional versions cook for 6–8 hours on very low heat, though 1–2 hours will still give good results.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The lentils are ready when they've turned deeply soft and the mixture has thickened into a rich, cohesive, almost stew-like consistency rather than looking like separate, whole beans.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy

04 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

In a separate kadai, melt the butter and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8–10 minutes — take your time here, as well-caramelized onions build real depth of flavor.

05 ADD AROMATICS AND TOMATO

Stir in the ginger-garlic paste and cook for a minute until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chili powder, and garam masala. Simmer for 10 minutes, until the mixture thickens and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy, continued



06 COMBINE WITH THE LENTILS

Pour the gravy into the pot of simmered lentils and beans, stirring to combine fully. Simmer together for another 20–30 minutes, adding water as needed to reach your preferred consistency.

07 FINISH WITH CREAM AND BUTTER

Stir in the cream and crushed kasuri methi, then finish with an extra pat of butter on top just before serving.

Color indicator. finished dal makhani should be deep brown, almost black, glossy, and thick enough to coat the back of a spoon.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Rushing the simmering time is the most common shortcut that produces a thin, unremarkable dal makhani. The long, slow simmer isn't optional flavor-building — it's what genuinely defines this dish.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with a swirl of cream and a pat of butter melting on top, alongside naan or steamed rice.
- A festive centerpiece dish at Punjabi weddings and family celebrations.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small copper handi with visible cream swirl, often garnished with a sprig of coriander.

Family Style

- A large shared pot at the center of the table, ladled generously over rice or scooped with naan.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Mashing some of the lentils against the pot as they simmer builds creaminess without needing excessive cream.
- A long, slow simmer at low heat is irreplaceable — there's no real shortcut to the depth it builds.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- This dish is an ideal make-ahead recipe — cook a large batch and freeze in portions for effortless future meals.
- Reheat gently, adding a splash of water or milk, and finish with fresh cream and butter each time for the best flavor.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some restaurants add a small piece of charred coal briefly to the pot, covered, for a smoky "dhungar" aroma reminiscent of the traditional tandoor-ember cooking method — an optional, advanced technique for those wanting an authentic smoky finish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

290 kcal	13 g	30 g	14 g	9 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Restaurant-Style Dal Makhani	an even richer version with extra butter and cream throughout cooking, not just at the end.
Dal Makhani without Cream	a lighter home-style version relying purely on the long simmer and butter for richness.
Vegan Dal Makhani	made with plant-based butter and cashew cream in place of dairy.

Can I skip the overnight soak?

It's strongly recommended, as unsoaked whole lentils and beans take considerably longer to cook and may not soften fully even in a pressure cooker.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why does restaurant dal makhani taste richer than mine?

Usually a longer simmer time and more butter and cream than most home cooks use. Don't be shy with either, and let the dish simmer as long as you can.

Can I make this in a slow cooker?

Yes — after pressure cooking the lentils, transfer everything to a slow cooker and let it simmer on low for 4–6 hours for an especially rich result.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary

GLOSSARY

Urad Dal (Sabut)	whole black lentils with their skin intact, the base of this dish.
Rajma	red kidney beans, added alongside the black lentils for texture and flavor.
Makhani	Hindi for "buttery," describing this rich style of gravy.
Dhungar	a smoking technique using charred coal to infuse a dish with smoky aroma.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Dal Makhani

15m	4–8h
ACTIVE PREP	SIMMER TIME
6	**Med**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

LENTILS

Whole black lentils	200 g
Red kidney beans	50 g
Water	1 L
Salt	6 g

GRAVY

Butter	60 g
Onion	150 g
Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
Tomato puree	240 ml
Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Heavy cream	60 ml
Kasuri methi	1 g
Salt	to taste

METHOD

01 **Soak overnight.** Rinse the black lentils and kidney beans together and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours.

02 **Pressure cook until very soft.** Drain and pressure cook the soaked lentils and beans with 4 cups fresh water and salt for 8–10 whistles, until completely soft and starting to break down — much softer than you'd cook lentils for most other dishes.

03 **Simmer and mash slightly.** Transfer to a heavy-bottomed pot and simmer gently for at least 1 hour, mashing some of the lentils against the side of the pot with your spoon as you stir — this is what builds the dish's characteristic creamy texture from within.

04 **Sauté the onions.** In a separate kadai, melt the butter and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8–10 minutes — take your time here, as well-caramelized onions build real depth of flavor.

05 **Add aromatics and tomato.** Stir in the ginger-garlic paste and cook for a minute until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chili powder, and garam masala.

06 **Combine with the lentils.** Pour the gravy into the pot of simmered lentils and beans, stirring to combine fully.

07 **Finish with cream and butter.** Stir in the cream and crushed kasuri methi, then finish with an extra pat of butter on top just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Whole black lentils	200 g	
☐	Salt	see recipe	
☐	Onion	150 g	
☐	Tomato puree	240 ml	
☐	Garam masala	1.5 g	
☐	Kasuri methi	1 g	
☐	Red kidney beans	50 g	
☐	Butter	60 g	
☐	Ginger-garlic paste	22 g	
☐	Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g	
☐	Heavy cream	60 ml	

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